





Morrison's run on *Batman Incorporated* has enabled him to keep on writing Damian Wayne, a character he played a large role in developing.

which freaked everybody out, then we came back. After that I had set up things, because I wrote these two issues to fill in, and had to fill them with this future plot, so suddenly I had that to deal with, and I felt I'd better just stay on and finish the story. It ended up turning into something quite interesting."

That was definitely the final stretch, however, with Morrison's last issue out in February 2013. "I felt as if I'd stayed on too long, so once I got this thing it gets quite sinister towards the end," he teases.

The writer is keen to stress that despite some of the headlines, he remains on good terms with the publisher. Indeed, he has more work with them in the following years. Much of his upcoming work with Vertigo and Image remains shrouded in mystery, however.

"Yeah it is a bit," Morrison smiles, "apart from *Seaguy 3*, the final *Seaguy* which I've told everyone I'm doing. But there's other stuff which I haven't talked about yet that's kinda getting done just now."

Is his focus, then, on more finite series rather than ongoing titles? "There's one idea I have, which is a long thing," he says, "because I haven't done anything like that for a while, but most of them are finite. I wanted to tell stories, you know? And again, getting away from some of the stuff that when you're working in the superhero universes it, as I've said before, it's not a real place. It's a real place in the sense that it's paper, but you're not writing about the real world; you're writing about this other world and the rules in that world and the relationships that form in that world, so there's a synthetic thing about it, which as much as I love it, it's not about here. And although Batman's about fighting against nihilism and the overwhelming sense of chaos in the universe, it's still stuck in the DC universe, and there might be more direct ways to say that. I just decided I want to tell some stories; you know, a beginning, middle and end, a really cool story that someone's sat you down in front of the fire and told you."



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> GRANT MORRISON

His current miniseries, *Happy!*, with art by Darick Robertson and published by Image Comics, is exactly that. Already attracting rave reviews, the tale of a loser in a hellhole of a town may not sound like something you'd want to read around the fire, but it comes with a spectacular twist: a tiny flying horse, full of optimism that only the protagonist can see.

"It's a really great design that Darick's done; it's just like a special effect. But yeah, when I was sitting thinking a couple of years ago, I had this idea that you know everyone takes the piss out of celebrities, and takes the piss out of singers and actors and everyone who's trying to create things, no matter how bad they are. I had this notion that a lot of these people are losing their minds doing this. You think, 'This is golden youth; you should be feeling a lot better.'

"So the whole thing became about that struggle, and then into it came this Christmas thing and this really nice little kidnap plot; it's everything horrible about the world. I've got paedophiles, drunks, methadone addicts, Santa Claus is a bastard, your lead character's a failure; he's got all kinds of problems. And into it comes this last fading thing; it doesn't really have long to live, that's what it's about."

With many of the writers and artists that have left DC and Marvel recently turning towards creator-owned projects, Image is quickly becoming one of the most successful publishers around.

"I look at them as almost like the HBO of comics," says Morrison, "where people are going with very specific ideas that maybe wouldn't be able to be published with any of the other companies. The creator-owned thing, for me, I've always owned my own stuff going back to the Seventies, so for me it's not a major issue. It's interesting to see that something's happening right now with a lot of people who have done superhero comics for a few years and started to move out and spread their wings a little bit. But there's always been, for me, a creator-owned book over here, plus a company-owned book over there running at the same time."

Morrison fans can rest assured, though, that he isn't turning his back on superheroes. His much-hyped *Multiversity* finally hit the shelves in August 2014, and the writer is clearly very attached to the characters he's been writing for the last few years. His Batman creation, Damien was also released into the animated movie world this year in *Son of Batman*.

"When you see Batman you have this lovely notion," Morrison laughs, "of 'well, I'll be like that one day, I'm gonna have a big dispenser on the wall, and it's got Caramac in it and Opal Fruits and salt and vinegar crisps, and that's what I'll have when I'm a millionaire.' And Batman's actually got that shit, you know? He's even branded them, so it'll be Batsalt and vinegar crisps. I think that's the appeal – the guy can do anything."

Most of the comics mentioned here are available from Comixology or on Kindle and are on sale in all good comic book stores.